Session 9

2025-04-06

1 - The cave mouth

~01:00, 26 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. At the cave's outer chamber, Amidamaru and Mialee face *three kobolds* who just jumped on them from deeper in the cave.
2. Below, the party who descended into the Tiamat-statue chamber haul themselves up the shaft — Nuberroca carrying the heavy wooden chest from the shrine up with him, *slow* under its weight — leaving the Roper *asleep* behind.
3. Nyx, remembering that the monster's bulk *deforms* enough to squeeze through narrow places, asks Nuberroca to help her tip the chamber's *bookshelf* across the shaft mouth. Between the two of them, the heavy shelf goes down and the hole is sealed.
4. Eguzkilore plants himself between the two doorways and *holds his shot for whatever moves first*.
5. Mialee opens with a clean arrow at the kobold closing on Amidamaru, the kobold drops and she hides back.
6. With the shelf in place, and unaware of her friends' struggle, Nyx walks across to Frulam Mondath's abandoned bed and lies down on it for a moment.
7. The remaining kobolds swarm Amidamaru — three blows in quick succession, the third lands hard. **Amidamaru collapses unconscious** at the cave mouth.
8. Nuberroca, hearing nothing from the bedroom, returns down the corridor. Eguzkilore is jammed in the doorway as a stopper — Nuberroca breaks into a run and squeezes past him through the narrow gap.
9. Mialee, from cover, threads another shot into a second kobold — the creature's eyes are on the downed tortle, not on her, and the arrow finds a vital spot. The third kobold remains.
10. Nuberroca, arriving at the scene, *hurls his greataxe* at the surviving kobold — the throw goes wide. *The kobold flinches as the spinning blade whirls over its head and embeds itself in a stone column behind it*. The stone cracks, but the kobold lives.
11. Mialee crosses to where Amidamaru is bleeding out and presses one of Nyx's *berries* into his mouth. The tortle comes back at the *threshold of life*. From cover behind a rock, Nyx threads a perfect shot into the last kobold and the chamber is silent again.

2 - The watch-cave

1. Nuberroca demands a long rest — *non-negotiable*. Amidamaru, *tortured during his captivity*, has not slept and presses for the same. Nyx is mostly fresh and offers to keep watch. They pull back to the small cave on the white cliffs — the one they had used to surveil the hideout the day before.
2. On the way out, Nuberroca pauses by the body of **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath** that the party left behind a few hours ago. He confirms the half-dragon is dead, then dislodges the greataxe and **decapitates him**. He fastens the head to his belt by a strap, *hanging visible*.
3. Inside the watch-cave, Nyx prepares a fresh batch of *berries* — ten in all, one for each teammate and five for herself. She tells Nuberroca that one berry sustains a person for the day and *heals a little*.
4. While the others bed down, Nyx asks Amidamaru what the cultists *wanted* from him during his captivity. He prefers not to discuss what they did to him, but volunteers that they wanted to know about **Leosin** *the monk*, *what we had done* with him and *where he was*. Nyx files the thread away — they will have to go looking for him once they are out of here.
5. As the last task before the watches begin, Mialee turns to the **wooden chest** Nuberroca had carried out — its lock already broken open by the goliath's scimitar pommel in the shrine chamber. Even so, the party stays cautious of whatever else the cult might have layered into it: Nuberroca sets the chest deep in the cave and steps well away, and from a safe distance Mialee conjures an unseen hand of force and works the lid open through it. A small *click* as the lid gives — nothing further.
6. The chest holds *pearls*, several *gems* of various sizes, a *fine ring* that takes no magical aura under Mialee's touch, a *broken-diamond fragment*, and a *necklace*, also non-magical. Mialee thinks the lot may belong to families in Greenest — they could return them.

3 - First light

~09:30, 26 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. The night watches pass without incident — eight hours of rest, no one approaching the cave. As the sun rises, a great flock of bats — *thousands, probably tens of thousands* — pours into the cave.
2. By full morning the party debates next steps. Nyx wants to push *north* into the cave system, but leaving the last dragon egg intact would be a problem. Eguzkilore and Mia report seeing no movement out of the cave through the night.
3. The party approaches the outer entrance and finds the whole place *strewn* with loose coins, scraps of cloth — *the kobolds' loincloths* — and assorted small junk. The Roper has *escaped*: Nyx reads the spread as the creature crawling out to feast on what was left of the kobold corpses.
4. Mialee, who never met the Roper, asks what they are about to face. Nyx describes it: *column-shaped*, *tentacled*, *massive*; it had hooked her by the chest yesterday before someone — Nuberroca, or maybe Eguzkilore — tore the tentacle off. *"Tortuga, cuidado, que como te coja el Roper..."*.

4 - Gold on the floor

~10:00, 26 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. Amidamaru — drawn by the *gold scattered on the floor* — strides ahead of the rest, scooping the most valuable pieces into his pack.
2. As he rounds one of the cave columns, *tentacles unfurl from it* — what he took for a pillar is the Roper itself, its bulk indistinguishable from the stone columns around it. In a single beat its tentacles snake out and seize *both* Amidamaru and Nuberroca — two tentacles each. *Sticky, needled* — pulling them in.
3. Nyx raises a binding of *coloured light* over the creature — its outline lights up across the cave, making the creature easier to target.
4. Amidamaru, gripped by the tentacles around his shell, throws his hands out in a *cone of fire* — straight at the Roper and the tentacles holding them. The creature twists away from the worst of the flare, protecting its body from most of the searing heat.
5. Eguzkilore advances and lines a shot at the lit-up creature, missing badly despite the clear angle. Nuberroca, restrained, brings the greatsword down on the tentacle around Amidamaru — the blow lands cleanly, but the tentacle holds.
6. The Roper draws its bound captives in 25 feet at a single pull, bites Nuberroca when close enough, and lashes fresh tentacles around Nyx and Eguzkilore as well — *the needles drive in and the strength runs out of them*.
7. Eguzkilore, still tangled, threads a perfect shot into the creature; the Roper *bleeds slightly*, but stays standing. The body is too large to feel a single arrow.
8. ***[EPIC]*** Amidamaru fires a second *cone of fire* across the Roper. The creature cannot twist clear this time; **every tentacle burns off**, freeing the grappled party in the same breath. *"No necesitamos a Sinsong, me tienen a mí"*.
9. Eguzkilore, pulling back to safer ground, takes a *bite* on the way out — heavy damage but he stays up. Mialee threads a shot into the Roper's flank with one of her last arrows. Nuberroca shares a little of his fury with Nyx while she stands behind him, *saving her life* with a thin shield of borrowed strength.
10. The Roper *grows six new tentacles in a single moment* and rises full again. Out of the new surge it lunges, opens its jaw, and bites Amidamaru — *the shell crunches* under the bite, blood streams from the tortle's flank, *one arm hangs useless* with the pain.
11. Nyx puts her full strength into a sword-swing — the blade, seething with dark energy, bites deeper than expected and the creature reels.
12. Amidamaru throws his third *cone of fire* — the Roper cannot twist clear again, every tentacle catches once more. The room fills with the stench of burning flesh.
13. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca pushes Amidamaru away from the monster and brings the greatsword down two-handed on the column's body. The Roper *gives* — the column begins to deform under the blow, *half-digested kobold flesh* sloughs out from underneath, and the whole creature collapses on the floor in an *unpleasant* wet heap. *"¡Espera que voy a echar la pota!"* — Nyx, vomiting berries.
14. A lone *kobold* who had stayed clear of the fight breaks for the inner cave; Eguzkilore levels his bow and *takes him down* with a single shot.
15. The party patches up afterward. Amidamaru hands Nuberroca a handful of pebbles he has *tinkered* to give off dim light at 5–10 feet — torches that don't need oil.

> *¡Espera que voy a echar la pota!*
>
> --- Nyx, *vomiting berries.*

5 – The barracks

1. The party heads back inward, going again towards the explored chambers. Mialee summons **Echo** — her *bat familiar* — and sends it ahead through the corridor to see what waits.
2. Echo, hanging from the ceiling, returns the count: **five kobolds and one drake** roosting on the old barracks beds. They are *making the place their own* — settling in.
3. Nuberroca decides to charge for the surprise. The kobold at the door sees him coming as he runs in — *no real surprise* — and the goliath's opening blow misses.
4. The kobolds fall back in coordinated pairs, working together. A net flies across the corridor and catches Eguzkilore, leaving him restrained, his bow useless.
5. Mialee — too far to cut him free in person — calls up an unseen hand of force, lifts a dagger from her own belt in mid-air, and slashes at the net with it. The net is weakened and Eguzkilore tears through the rest with a pull.
6. Nuberroca rakes through the kobold line with the greatsword, swinging recklessly. He takes hits — kobold *darts* and the drake's bite-and-tail-strike — but his fury holds the worst of it back, a faint *blue glow* knitting each fresh cut closed as it opens.
7. Nyx pulls a clean shot into the drake from her cover — she has had it tracked since the start of the fight, making the shot more damaging. By then Eguzkilore drops the last kobold standing in the corridor with a precise arrow.
8. With only the drake left in the room, Mialee threads a follow-up shot into it from her flank. The drake totters but doesn't fall.
9. Nuberroca squares with the drake from a flanking angle and brings the greatsword down in a lethal arc. The drake takes the blow and dies on the floor.

6 – Down the rope

1. With the barracks clear, Nuberroca walks over to Amidamaru with his *arm bleeding and badly cut up* and asks for help. Amidamaru, deadpan — *I can help you, but that's where my help ends*. Nuberroca calls on the cleric — *"Sinsong, cúrame"* — and Sinsong weaves a powerful healing over the goliath; Nuberroca is brought back nearly whole.
2. The party walks back to Frulam's quarters. Nyx confirms her suspicion — the *bookshelf barricade* across the shaft is *broken through*, the area beyond wrecked. The Roper had to smash through the shelf to get past — it had forced its way out before dawn.
3. Nyx volunteers to scout the lower chamber first — *quiet, alone, then signal up*. She slides down the rope and lands behind cover. From her position she messages her partners: *clear*.
4. The party drops down the rope into the south-west corner of the shrine chamber, but before they can push out from the landing Nyx signals them — *kobolds, many*.

7 – The shrine

~10:30, 26 Marpenoth 1489 DR

1. As soon as the party pushes into the chamber, the kobolds — *prepared and waiting* — open with a hail of *sling-stones* from cover. Others dart in close, daggers out, less to wound than to *keep the heroes hemmed in* — and with the party hard-pressed at arm's reach, the slingers' stones find their marks almost every time.
2. Mialee, who had held still to steady her aim, finally lands a clean shot — the arrow slips past a kobold's guard; Nyx ribs her that it's her first all morning.
3. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca hauls **Langdedrosa Cyanwrath's severed head** off his belt and *brandishes it* at the kobolds. His fury and the trophy together make the threat work; three kobolds *break and run, frightened*.
4. Nyx, badly bloodied, pulls back behind a table for cover. The remaining kobolds press into the corridor mouth.
5. With the halfling safe, the party closes the wave down — Amidamaru slays a kobold at the corridor mouth, Nuberroca *pulps* another outright, a *bolt of fire* takes a third, and Eguzkilore's bow drops one more. The last of the ambushers — those not already cut down or routed — break and flee into the dark.
6. With the first wave broken and a brief lull, Nyx points out the dragon egg the previous night had left intact. Mialee asks what to do: break it or carry it. Nuberroca, from across the chamber, settles it — *"¡Destruid el huevo!"*.

7. Mia slips through the iron gate into the **hatchery** and strikes the egg with a sharp blow — the shell holds. She then pours the last of her oil across the straw of the nest and lights it as she retreats back toward the shrine.
8. The fire is barely settling when a fresh wave of kobolds — slipped in unseen through the side tunnels while the party's eyes were on the egg — falls on them.
9. The kobold pack focuses on Eguzkilore — crowding in close so their blows land thick and fast; he **goes down** on the chamber floor, breath shallow, and the press of kobolds walls him off — none of his partners can cut through to reach him.
10. The kobolds then turn on Amidamaru — stones and a dagger driven home as the pack closes around him — and **the tortle drops to the ground**, slumping unconscious at the tunnel mouth he had been watching. His breath shallows alongside the elf's.
11. Meanwhile Nyx, half-broken behind her table and *out of options*, weaves an illusion of a kobold over herself — *as close to one of theirs as she can manage*. She steps out and orders the kobolds, in Common, *not to kill the others — the mistress wants them alive, especially the elf*. Her accent slips — Common is not the kobolds' tongue — but the survivors begin to *repeat orders back to those behind them* in Draconic that the party cannot understand.
12. ***[EPIC]*** Eguzkilore's body lurches once more against the dark — a last shudder runs the length of the elf, his hand scrabbling weakly at the cold stone for a bow that is no longer in reach. Blood spreads black beneath him in the half-light; the breath rattles slow out of his chest and does not draw back. **Eguzkilore *dies* on the floor of the Tiamat chamber**, under the five-headed statue and the guttering flame of the candles — beyond any saving.
13. The kobolds, *not killing for sport* and now seemingly under the disguised orders, send one of their own across to attempt to *stabilise* the elf, but Eguzkilore is already gone. The kobolds begin to *drag the body out* toward the cave entrance. Amidamaru stabilises quietly in the background as the fight winds down.

8 - The bat-cave

1. While the fight in the Tiamat chamber was raging, Nuberroca had broken away down the tunnel he'd been guarding, set on learning how the kobold reinforcements were reaching them so fast. The way was *near-black*, but he could make out their tracks and **a flight of stairs they had descended**. As he cleared the stairs, *the ceiling caved in* — not on top of him, but sealing the corridor at his back.
2. Unable to see, he took out one of the *glowing pebbles* Amidamaru had given him and pressed on by its dim light. A stretch of floor *gave way* under his weight, and *poisoned needles hidden underneath* drove into his foot — he shook off the worst, but the poison left him *light-headed*, not quite drugged.
3. The cave opened around him: the floor thick with *bat guano*, scattered with small *bat corpses* drained dry — *husks, desiccated*. Far overhead, past the reach of his light, the ceiling was *alive with thousands of bats* — heard more than seen.
4. Nuberroca worked his way along, *hugging the wall* on the broken ground, hunting for anything useful — *potions, weapons*. By a *pile of old bones* in the north he caught a *glint* of something down in the refuse and moved to take it.
5. The *stench* hit him first. *Four troglodytes* — reptilian and foul — uncoiled from cracks in the wall, already almost on him; in the dark his sight reached barely ten feet. They pressed him from every side with tooth and claw; his *shield* turned most of it, but one raking blow got through. *Cornered*, the barbarian knew the fight here was not winnable in numbers.
6. Nuberroca *winks into a swirl of cloud* and re-forms thirty feet clear of the pack, the troglodytes letting him go. The way he came in is sealed by the cave-in behind him, so he strikes out by another route — and catches the *soft purple glow* of the fungi chamber the party had pushed through on its first descent into the cave. He makes for the light and works his way back toward the *entry chamber*.

9 – Mialee's gambit

1. Mialee, taking Nyx's disguise as the model, weaves an illusion of a kobold over herself — *taller than most but small enough to pass for the largest of theirs*. She steps out among the wreckage and tells the kobolds in front of her, in Common, *that there is nothing here*.
2. Mia then remembers the *trap plate* Nyx had warned the party about — the floor plate under where the chest had sat. She calls up her unseen hand of force and presses the plate from above.
3. ***[EPIC]*** The *hissing* rises in the chamber again. *Acid pours from every dragon mouth* in the walls; the spraying is followed by the *vapour cloud*. **Most of the kobolds in the chamber die**, choking in the spray or the gas; *four* survive and bolt. Mialee, caught by the spray, takes a hit of acid burn herself.
4. **Amidamaru**, unconscious on the floor, catches the spray and the gas with everyone else. The first lash of acid strips away the fragile hold that had kept him steady; the choking cloud behind it drives the next breath wrong in his chest. He is no longer merely down — he is *dying*.

10 – The long way out

1. Nyx, in her kobold disguise, walks out alongside the *kobold dragging Eguzkilore's body* — taking up the second arm to help carry the elf toward the entrance. Along the corridor she cuts the helper kobold's throat.
2. Nuberroca, returning at a dash from the bat-cave, meets a *kobold* in the corridor that calls out *"Soy Nyx"* in his face. He picks the creature up by the head, finds *the skull does not match the kobold* it should be under the illusion, and sets her down again. Together with Eguzkilore's body between them, they make for the cave entrance.
3. Mialee, *still in the kobold-illusion*, crosses the wreckage of the Tiamat chamber to **Amidamaru**, drops a *berry* into his mouth, and tells him to run — *back the way we came in, the path is clear*.
4. At the cave entrance, Sinsong receives Eguzkilore's body. He weaves a magical ward over the corpse to *halt decay* — ten days before the chance of resurrection closes. The dwarf declines to spend his remaining power on healing the others while there is still a body to keep.
5. The kobolds returning to the chamber, alerted by Mialee and Amidamaru's run, charge to intercept. Stones rain down from several angles at once; one catches Amidamaru on the run and **the tortle drops again**. Mia finds herself overtaken by the survivors closing on her position.